



Bauhaus

Location Dessau, Germany

The Bauhaus, the renowned design school in Germany, was founded by Walter Gropius in Weimar in 1919. It was moved to Dessau 6 years later, and it was here, in 1925–1926, that Gropius designed the school’s buildings. They had all the elements of the Modernism that Gropius championed. The buildings were entirely faithful to his belief that truth—and hence worth—in architecture could only be the product of utility. Curves were banished, as was any decoration. Above all, in an industrial age, only industrial materials—steel, glass, and concrete—were used. Windows were regular and repeated; the complex of interlocking buildings formed a series of right angles. In 1932, the school moved to Berlin. Running afoul of the Nazis, it closed the following year.

▲ GERMAN SCULPTOR GEORG KOLBE’S SCULPTURE ALBA AT THE GERMAN PAVILION

German Pavilion

Location Barcelona, Spain

Walter Gropius’s successor as head of the Bauhaus was the German architect Ludwig Mies van der Rohe. Although a believer in Gropius’s ideas, the pavilion he designed as the official German contribution to the 1929 Barcelona International Exposition reflected his own characteristic use of opulent materials. By using marble in spaces that were geometrically pure, almost abstract, he created an understated luxuriance that remained functional. The German Pavilion contained little more than examples of Mies van der Rohe’s Barcelona chair—an instant icon of modern design. This reflected the fact that while other countries had used buildings to house their exhibits, van der Rohe’s building was itself the exhibit.

Villa Savoye

Location Poissy, France

Outside the Bauhaus, no architect more precisely reflected the stern intellectual demands of Modernism in the 1920s than the Swiss-French Le Corbusier. His *Vers Une Architecture* (1923) was a rallying call for a new architecture reflecting a socialist world. Henceforth, buildings were to be “machines for living,” and his Villa Savoye, built in 1929, was a precise expression of this theory. Long, low, and starkly white, it is raised from the ground on plain concrete columns (see pp.192–193). All the living spaces, surrounded by rectangular windows, are located on the open-plan second floor, which overlooks a similarly stark roof garden. Encapsulating the Modernist style, Villa Savoye was one of the most influential 20th-century buildings.

Tugendhat House

Location Brno, Czech Republic

Mies van der Rohe’s Tugendhat House, built between 1928 and 1930, was designed as a deliberately lavish domestic villa, built without regard to cost while also remaining true to the structural and architectural demands of Modernism. If its planning was stark, its materials were certainly not. The villa is built on a steeply sloping site, with the main entrance at street level. Stairs lead down to a sweeping living room, 80 ft (24 m) long by 40 ft (12 m) wide, and the garden front is given over to floor-to-ceiling windows. An onyx partition adds an air of obvious luxury. The sense of spaces flowing together is immediate. Further unity is provided by the decorative details, all designed by the architect.